

THE EMPEROR WHO WOULD NOT KNEEL

Chapter 4 — “The Wastes”

Format: Traditional right-to-left manga script. Read panels right-to-left, top-to-bottom.

Black-and-white. Heavy ink shadow, cinematic negative space, screentone.

Approx. 24 pages.

PAGE 1

Panels: 3 (silent page)

Panel 1 (wide, full-width top)

The Gray has swallowed them. No horizon. No gates behind. Only a ceiling of low bone-colored cloud pressed flat against the land. EGRIS and ARGHUN are small figures walking through featureless mist. No dialogue.

Panel 2 (narrow, ground-level detail)

Close on their boots crunching across something that isn't stone, isn't bone — something between. The texture is wrong.

SFX: `krnch... krnch...`

Panel 3 (wide, bottom)

ARGHUN stops walking and looks down at the ground beneath his feet, horrified.

No dialogue.

PAGE 2

Panels: 3

Panel 1

ARGHUN, pale, voice tight.

ARGHUN: “What is this?”

Panel 2

EGRIS, not stopping, not looking down.

EGRIS: “The remains of someone's world.”

Panel 3 (wide — Arghun clutches his satchel tighter and says nothing more)

The two men continue walking, the mist closing in around them.

NARRATION (box): They walked.

PAGE 3

Panels: 4

Panel 1 (large)

Shapes move in the mist to either side — barely visible, just suggestions. A faint glow where eyes might be. The hint of a figure watching.

SFX (faint, layered): ...ssshhh...

Panel 2

Close on EGRIS's eyes — alert, tracking motion without turning his head.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

ARGHUN whispers, terrified.

ARGHUN: "The Hollow. I told you."

Panel 4

EGRIS, calm.

EGRIS: "These are not the Hollow you described."

PAGE 4**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

ARGHUN glances at the watching shapes in the mist.

ARGHUN: "No. These are the ones who still remember enough to be afraid."

Panel 2 (narrow, silent — Egris files that away)

Close on Egris's face. A flicker of thought.

No dialogue.

Panel 3 (wide, atmospheric)

The two men walking. The watching shapes recede, never coming close. Time moves strangely — no change in light, no lengthening shadows.

NARRATION (box): They walked for what could have been a day or an hour. Time moved strangely in the Gray.

PAGE 5**Panels: 1** (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — page-turn reveal)

The RUINS appear suddenly, as though the mist pulled back a curtain. Collapsed buildings — stone and iron twisted at angles that hurt to look at. Some had been homes. Others fortifications. A few too large and shattered to identify.

At the center, huddled against the base of a tilting tower: SOULS. Dozens of them, sitting or lying in the ash, bodies marked by the wounds that killed them, eyes dull with exhaustion.

No dialogue.

PAGE 6

Panels: 4

Panel 1

The souls don't see Egris and Arghun at first. Some tend to others. Most simply wait.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

Then one of them looks up — a WOMAN, broad-shouldered, a rope-line scar around her neck. She was hanged. She stares at Egris like a soldier seeing an enemy on the hill.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

The WOMAN's voice cuts across the camp.

WOMAN: "Get back."

Panel 4 (wide — the camp stirs)

The other souls react. Hands go to phantom weapons. Bodies shift closer together. Children (three of them) press behind a wall of grown bodies.

No dialogue.

PAGE 7

Panels: 3

Panel 1

ARGHUN starts to speak.

ARGHUN: "We are not here to—"

Panel 2

EGRIS cuts him off, flat and immediate.

EGRIS: "Be quiet."

Panel 3

ARGHUN falls silent. The scribe knows when to obey.

No dialogue.

PAGE 8

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (large)

EGRIS studies the grouped souls. Not soldiers — not all of them. Farmers with broken hands. A merchant with a blade-wound. Warriors stand ready among them, weight on the balls of their feet.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

The HANGED WOMAN speaks again, voice hard.

WOMAN: "Who are you?"

Panel 3

EGRIS, simple.

EGRIS: "Someone walking through."

PAGE 9**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

The WOMAN, cold.

WOMAN: "Walk faster."

Panel 2

EGRIS almost smiles — a flicker, gone before it fully forms.

No dialogue.

Panel 3 (wide)

Instead he studies the ruins. The walls are broken violently, not by time. Long gouges in the stone, as if clawed.

No dialogue.

Panel 4

EGRIS: "Something hunts you."

PAGE 10**Panels: 3****Panel 1 (large)**

The WOMAN's face changes — not to fear, but to something deeper. The recognition of a truth spoken aloud at last.

WOMAN: "The Hollow Men."

Panel 2

WOMAN: "They come at the thick of the dark. They take one or two each time. We never see them clearly. Only the shape. Only the reaching."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "How long?"

PAGE 11**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

The WOMAN, exhausted.

WOMAN: "Long enough that we no longer count the ones they have taken."

Panel 2

EGRIS looks at ARGHUN. The scribe has already found a brush and a scrap of pale material. He is

WRITING — instinct, without being asked.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

EGRIS turns back to the ruins.

EGRIS: "Where do they come from?"

Panel 4

The WOMAN points toward a gap between collapsed structures — deeper mist, darker ground.

WOMAN: "The deep Gray. Beyond the ruins. We do not go there."

PAGE 12

Panels: 3

Panel 1

EGRIS: "Show me."

Panel 2

The WOMAN stares at him.

WOMAN: "You want to go toward them?"

Panel 3 (large)

EGRIS: "I want to see what I am dealing with."

PAGE 13

Panels: 4

Panel 1

WOMAN: "You are not dealing with anything. You are passing through."

Panel 2

EGRIS, calm, certain — a man realizing something about himself.

EGRIS: "I was. I am not anymore."

Panel 3 (narrow, silent — the woman studies him)

No dialogue.

Panel 4

The WOMAN points again toward the gap.

WOMAN: "There. But wait for the dark. They will come to us first. They always do."

PAGE 14

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (large, top — atmospheric shift)

The dark comes like a held breath released. The dim Gray becomes BLACK — not night, but something

closing around them. Mist thickens until nothing is visible beyond arm's reach.

SFX: fwooooo

Panel 2 (wide, bottom — the camp huddled)

The souls press together. Warriors take position at wall-gaps, gripping sharpened stones and broken metal. ARGHUN stands beside EGRIS, clutching his satchel.

No dialogue.

PAGE 15

Panels: 3

Panel 1

ARGHUN whispers.

ARGHUN: "Tell me you have a plan."

Panel 2

EGRIS, calm.

EGRIS: "I have observation."

Panel 3

ARGHUN, dry despair.

ARGHUN: "That is not a plan."

EGRIS: "It is the beginning of one."

PAGE 16

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (wide, oppressive silence)

No dialogue.

SFX (rising, wet): ...ssssssh...

Panel 2

Close on EGRIS's ear — he hears it. A sound like wet cloth dragged over stone. Everywhere and nowhere.

SFX: sshhhhhh

Panel 3 (narrow, tense)

No dialogue.

The sound continues, slipping below hearing, then rising.

PAGE 17

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — the Hollow Men emerge)

They come from the dark between the ruins. NOT men — only the shape of men. Two arms, two legs, a head. But their outlines shimmer and blur, as if drawn in ash and smeared before drying. They move soundlessly. Their eyes: dull gray light, flat as coins.

Seven of them.

SFX: (total silence except the wet-dragging sound)

— END OF PAGE (page-turn tension) —

PAGE 18

Panels: 4

Panel 1

The HOLLOW MEN move through gaps in the wall without rushing. They have done this many times.
No dialogue.

Panel 2

The warriors in the ruins raise their weapons — broken metal, sharpened stone.
No dialogue.

Panel 3 (large, horror beat)

One HOLLOW MAN reaches for an OLD MAN sitting against the wall. It touches him.
No dialogue.

Panel 4

The old man goes STILL. His features begin to blur, soften. His mouth opens to scream — no sound comes.
SFX: (silence)

PAGE 19

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (large)

The old man FADES. His presence drains like water from a broken cup. In seconds, he is one of them — a new Hollow Man rising where he sat, outline already shimmering.
No dialogue.

Panel 2

The warriors ATTACK. Their weapons pass through the Hollow Men like smoke. Nothing solid to strike.
SFX: swsh— swsh—

Panel 3 (wide, panic spreading)

Another soul is taken. Then another. The camp is breaking.
No dialogue.

PAGE 20

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS watches. Studying the way they move — always the edges, always the weakest point.
No dialogue.

Panel 2

A warrior swings iron through a Hollow Man's chest. The creature RECOILS — barely, but it recoils.
No dialogue.

Panel 3

Close on EGRIS's eyes. He saw it. They can be disturbed.
No dialogue.

Panel 4

The HANGED WOMAN behind him, gripping a broken wall.
WOMAN: "You cannot fight them. No one can."

PAGE 21**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

EGRIS picks up a length of collapsed beam — heavy dark wood, splintered at one end.
EGRIS: "Everything can be fought. You just have not found how."

Panel 2 (wide)

He walks toward the Hollow Men. ARGHUN calls after him. Egris does not stop.
ARGHUN (off-panel): "Egris—!"

Panel 3

EGRIS swings the beam through the space where a Hollow Man exists. It passes through — but the creature FLINCHES.
SFX: SWSH

PAGE 22**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

The HOLLOW MAN turns its flat gray eyes toward Egris. For a moment, nothing moves.
No dialogue.

Panel 2

EGRIS understands. They feed on stillness. On resignation. What disturbs them is not violence — it is WILL.
NARRATION (box): They fed on stillness. On souls who had already accepted they would be taken.

Panel 3

EGRIS drops the beam. He steps forward until he stands between the Hollow Men and the souls.
SFX: thud (beam hitting ground)

PAGE 23

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (large)

EGRIS speaks aloud, facing the Hollow Men.

EGRIS: “You want memory. You want identity. You want what these people still have.”

Panel 2

The Hollow Men watch him.

EGRIS: “You cannot take it from me. I will not let you.”

Panel 3 (wide, bottom)

EGRIS: “And while I stand here, you will have to go through me to reach them.”

PAGE 24

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — the confrontation)

The largest HOLLOW MAN — a shape that might once have been a woman — moves toward Egris. He does NOT step back. It reaches. Its hand touches his chest.

EGRIS feels it — a cold pulling at something deep. The first battle he ever won. The name of his first horse. The color of his wife’s eyes. The Gray trying to take them.

But EGRIS HOLDS. Jaw set, eyes burning, fist clenched. The refusal is bone-deep.

The Hollow Man RECOILS. Its shape wavers violently. Its gray eyes flicker.

Then it turns away.

No dialogue this page — silent power struggle, visual only.

PAGE 25

Panels: 3

Panel 1

All the Hollow Men turn away. They move back into the gaps between ruins, dissolving into dark like ink into water.

SFX (fading): ...ssshhh...

Panel 2

The wet-dragging sound fades. The blackness thins by degrees.

No dialogue.

Panel 3 (wide — the Hollow Men are gone)

EGRIS stands in the silence that follows. His chest aches where the thing touched him — not physical. Something had been pulled, tested, nearly torn. It held only because he refused to let go.

No dialogue.

PAGE 26

Panels: 3

Panel 1

Close on EGRIS's hand. It is shaking.
No dialogue.

Panel 2

He curls it into a fist. The shaking stops.
SFX: `clench`

Panel 3 (wide)

The souls in the ruins stare at him. Not grateful. Wary. They recognize him now — not his face, but his NAME.
No dialogue.

PAGE 27

Panels: 4

Panel 1

The HANGED WOMAN steps forward.
WOMAN: "You saved us."

Panel 2

EGRIS, flat.
EGRIS: "I stood between you and something that wanted to feed on you."

Panel 3

WOMAN: "Is that not the same thing?"

Panel 4 (tight on Egris)

EGRIS: "Not if you fear the man who stands in front of you more than the thing behind him."

PAGE 28

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (wide, heavy silence)

The warriors look at one another. The farmers lower their eyes. The children press closer to the adults.
No one thanks him. No one curses him either.
No dialogue.

Panel 2

NARRATION (box): They simply watched him with the wariness of people who had been saved by a monster and did not yet know whether the monster expected payment.

Panel 3

Close on EGRIS's face — a small, uncomfortable feeling. He is not used to caring what they think of him.
No dialogue.

PAGE 29

Panels: 3

Panel 1

EGRIS turns to ARGHUN.

EGRIS: "Write this down."

Panel 2

ARGHUN, still clutching his brush.

ARGHUN: "What part?"

Panel 3

EGRIS: "All of it. The Hollow. The ruins. The way they move and the way they break. Everything you saw."

PAGE 30

Panels: 2

Panel 1

ARGHUN looks at him.

ARGHUN: "Will you stay?"

Panel 2 (wide, bottom — Egris looks at the ruins, at the souls, at the dark beyond)

EGRIS: "For now."

PAGE 31

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — closing image)

Wide shot of the ruins at rest. The souls settling back into the camp. EGRIS standing at the edge, looking out at the dark where the Hollow Men vanished. ARGHUN beside him, writing by faint light. The three children watching from behind the woman in red.

NARRATION (box, lower corner): It was not a promise. It was not a command. It was something he offered because he chose to — and that, in the Wastes, was enough to begin.

— END OF CHAPTER 4 —

SCRIPT NOTES (for artist / letterer)

- **Reading direction:** Right-to-left. Panel 1 sits at top-right of every page.
- **This is a horror/action chapter.** The Hollow Men must feel genuinely threatening — use visual language of body-horror (smeared outlines, wrong proportions, empty eyes).
- **Page 17 splash (Hollow Men emerge)** is the centerpiece scare. Keep Page 16 quiet and dark so the reveal lands hard.

- **Page 24 splash (Egris vs. the Hollow)** is the emotional climax — this is NOT a physical fight. It's a battle of will. Show it through Egris's clenched fist, set jaw, refusal in his eyes. The Hollow Man recoiling should feel like it hit a wall it didn't know existed.
- **The souls' reaction (Pages 26-28)** — they are NOT grateful. They are AFRAID of him. Draw that clearly: averted eyes, protective huddles, wariness. This is the weight Egris will carry.
- **Arghun's role:** he is always writing when something important happens. It's instinct. Show his ink-stained fingers moving even during tense moments.
- **Tone:** This chapter shifts Egris from "walking through" to "staying." Mark that visually — by the end, he is positioned protectively at the edge of the camp, no longer a passerby.